

13. Source: Meeting with the representatives of the local hospital staff, which includes local tribespeople

The Health for All (HfA) delegation, aiming to gain a deeper understanding of the ongoing crisis, paid a visit to the director of the local hospital where the HfA surgical team usually operates. According to the director of the local hospital in Beta Town:

Due to the absence of professional staff and the suspension of HfA's assistance, the hospital is non-operational. This has led to patients being sent back home, some without receiving critical surgeries. One such patient succumbed to his injuries from a road accident. A growing measles outbreak is of further concern, given the lack of a vaccination program and the expertise to spearhead one.

In this context, the director emphasized the urgency of addressing the ongoing labor dispute. Local staff rely heavily on their salaries, making timely payments crucial for their families.

The delegation insisted to see the safe release of its international staff before discussing the sources of the dispute with the staff of the hospital. Having its staff taken hostage by tribespeople is not a way to engage in a productive discussion. Clarifying misconceptions, the director stated the detained staff members aren't hostages but are being treated as guests, owing to the region's hospitable traditions. According to the director, a more pressing concern arises from the local guards, particularly the grievances of the families of those killed in prior violence. These families anticipate compensation from HfA. Unlike hospital staff, who can liaise with HfA through the director, guards fall under tribal leaders' purview. There's ambiguity surrounding these tribal leaders' dependence on local guards and their affiliations with former militias. The director urged HfA to reconsider its decision to withdraw, given the measles outbreak and the time required to find an alternative service provider. The delegation reiterated the importance of their Gamma mission but showed willingness to seek a compromise. The delegation's immediate priority remains the safe release of detained staff. Subsequent discussions will focus on resuming hospital activities and HfA's future operations in the district.